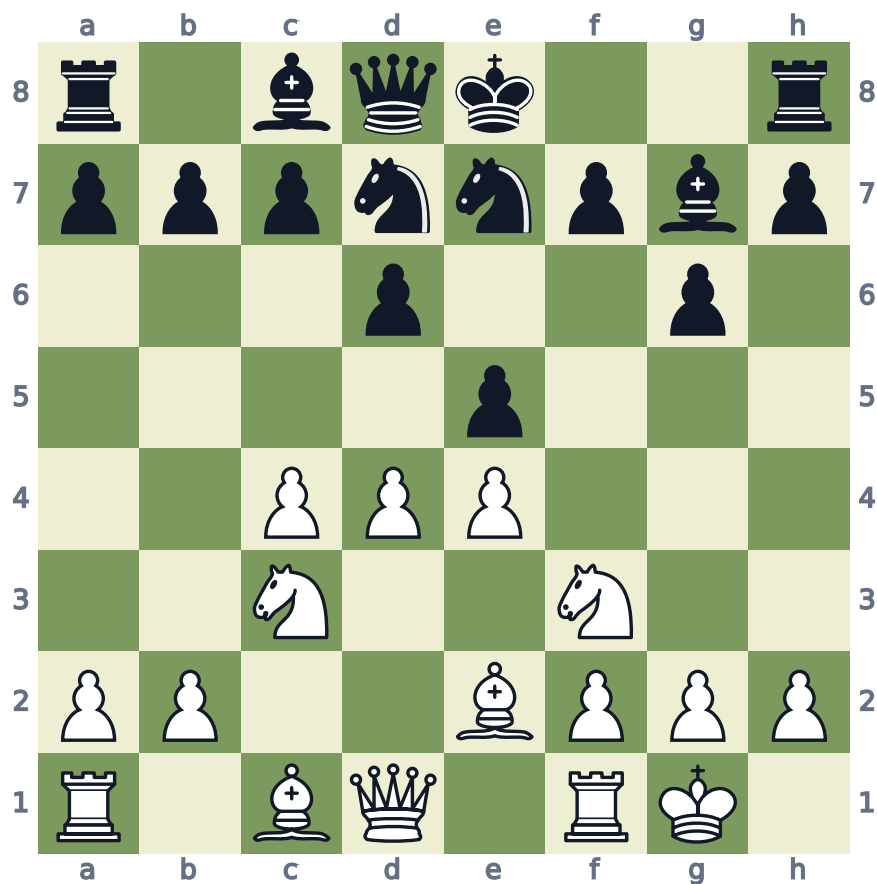


The Hippo e5 Break

Central contact, exchanges, closed centers, and the price of committing the e-pawn



Judge when e5 is Black's best liberating move, calculate White's three main replies, and reorganize the pieces after the center changes.

8 learning units | solid-piece diagrams | recall tests | engine checks

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Judge when e5 is Black's best liberating move, calculate White's three main replies, and reorganize the pieces after the center changes.

THE HIPPO TRAINING LOOP

- First identify the center, both kings, and the opponent's most forcing pawn break.
- At every diagram, name the urgent threat and compare e5, c5, f5, and b5.
- Hide the answer until you have spoken the move, its purpose, and the opponent's best reply.
- Replay each branch from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected Black core repertoire. It teaches setup, exceptions, transformation, and resulting plans; the PGN companions make later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

The e5 break attacks d4 and claims central dark squares.

PRINCIPLE 2

If White closes with d5, Black needs a second break rather than passive piece shuffling.

PRINCIPLE 3

If White exchanges, the opened lines change which bishop and knight are good.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

e5 can weaken d5 and f5, so piece support must be counted first.

PRINCIPLE 5

A rook on e1 can make the timing tactical.

PRINCIPLE 6

The break is successful when it improves piece activity, not merely when the pawn survives.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

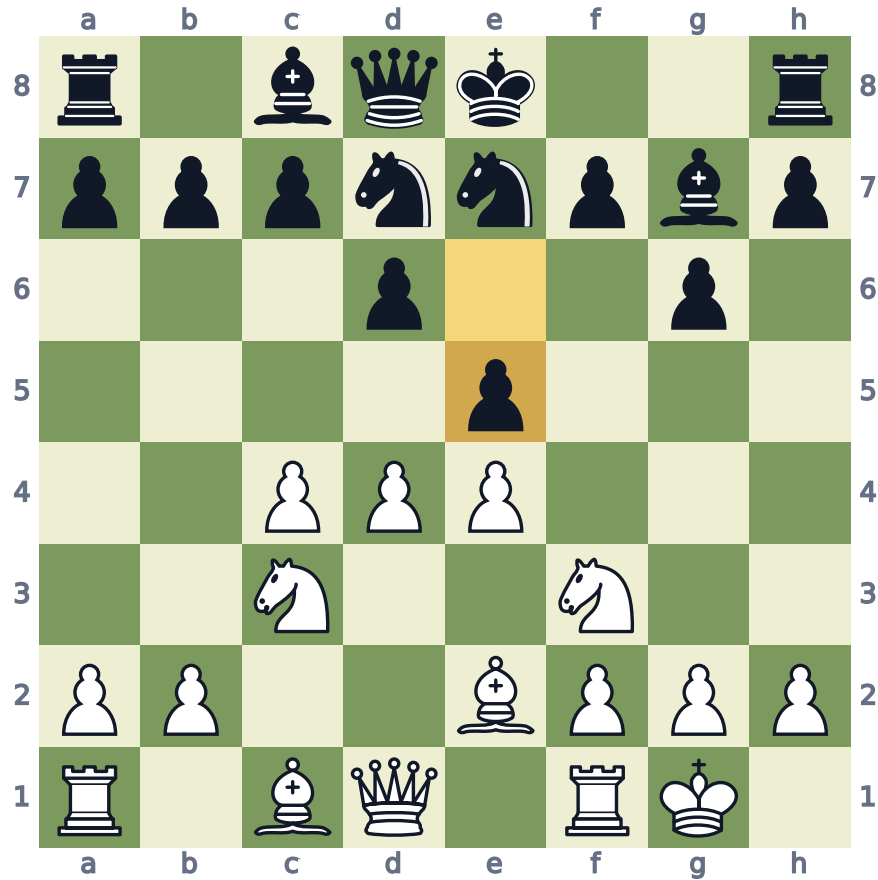
- | | | |
|-----------|---|---|
| 01 | e5 against the classical d4 center | Before e5, calculate d5, dxe5, and the tension-maintaining reply. |
| 02 | e5 against a rook on e1 | A rook on e1 makes the break more tactical, not automatically bad. |
| 03 | e5 against the Austrian center | Against f4, e5 is a race against White's own e5 push. |
| 04 | e5 with White's c-pawn committed | The broad center gives targets, but only if contact happens before it advances. |
| 05 | e5 in a fianchetto center | After e5-d5, plan the second break before accepting the closed center. |
| 06 | e5 against the Botvinnik English | When White cannot play d4 easily, e5 can create a useful closed chain. |
| 07 | White closes before Black breaks | A closed chain is not sacred; remove its base when the exchange improves development. |
| 08 | e5 against long castling | Against long castling, central contact and queenside files must be coordinated. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

e5 against the classical d4 center



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 Nd7 7. O-O e5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Attack d4, free the queen and knights, and force White to define the center.

MAIN DANGER

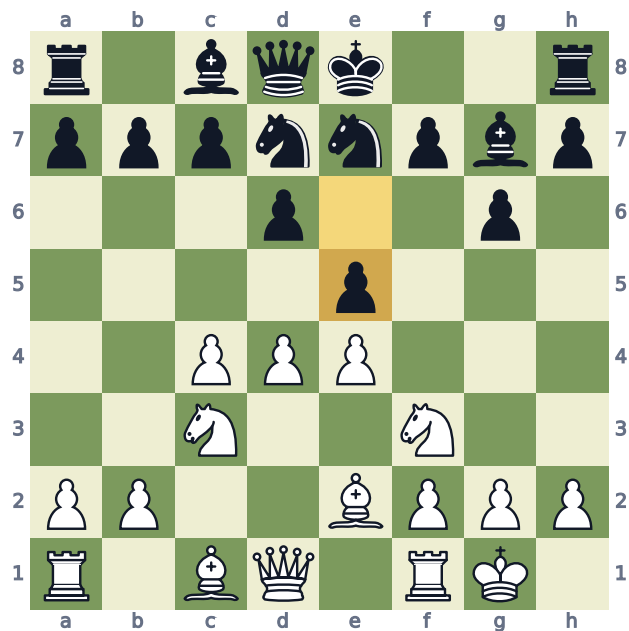
d5 gains space and can leave Black's pieces short of squares.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Before e5, calculate d5, dxe5, and the tension-maintaining reply.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.33 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. dxe5 Nxe5 2. Nxe5 Bxe5 3. Be3 Bxc3 4. bxc3 Nc6 5. Bh6 Qh4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

e5 against the classical d4 center



YOUR TASK

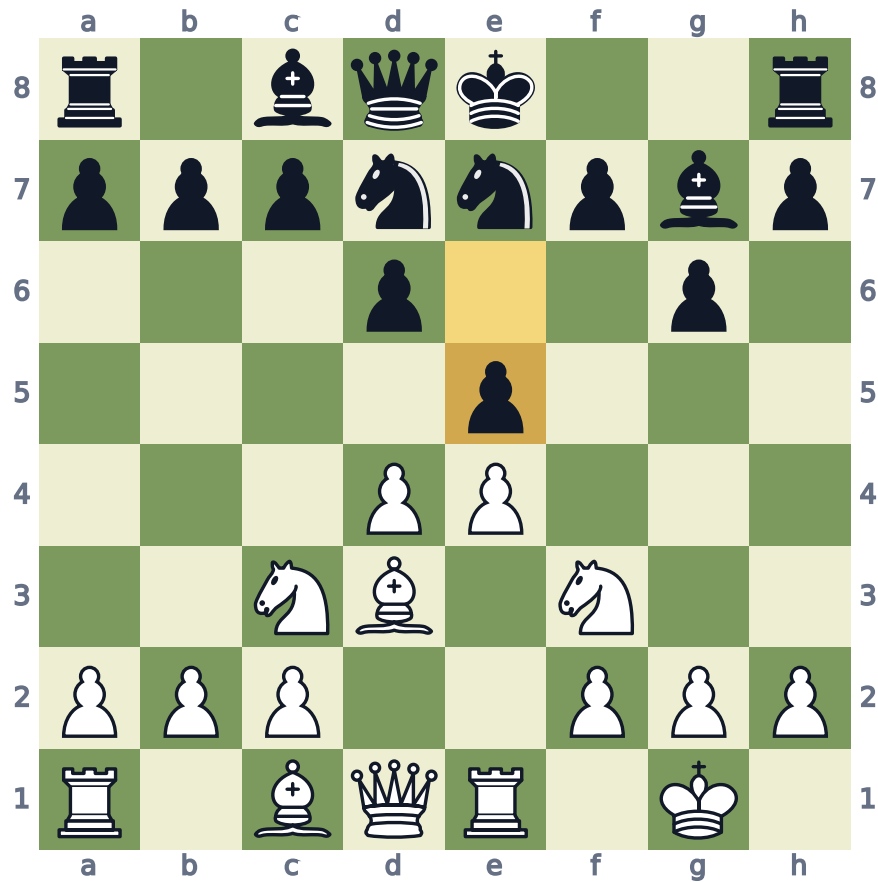
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

e5 against a rook on e1



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7 7. Re1 e5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

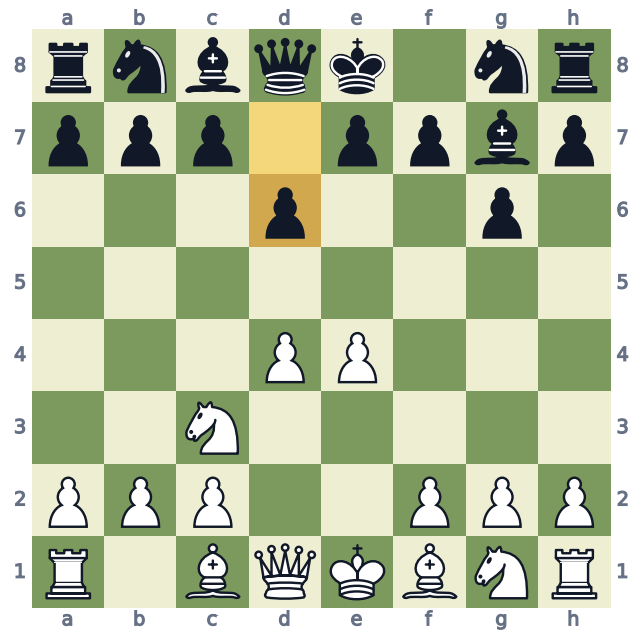
Challenge d4 while using piece support to survive e-file tactics.

MAIN DANGER

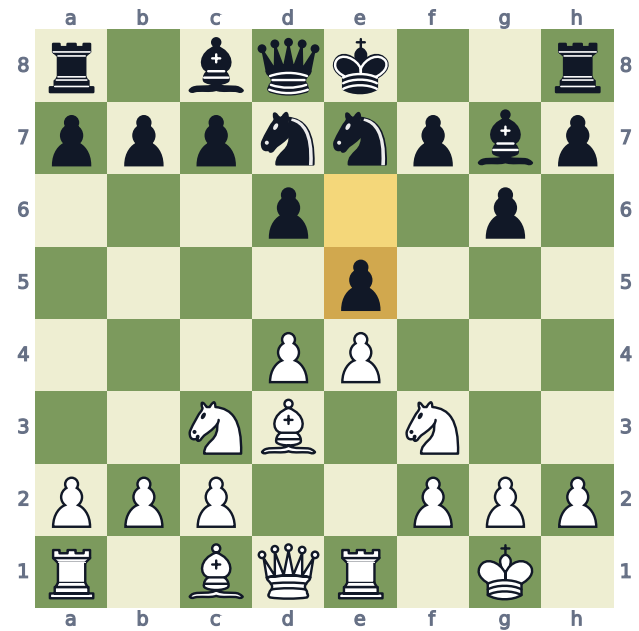
dx e5 can expose the rook against the e-pawn or queen.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A rook on e1 makes the break more tactical, not automatically bad.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.17 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. dxe5 Nxe5 2. Nxe5 dxe5 3. Bc4 Qxd1 4. Rxd1 c6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

e5 against a rook on e1



YOUR TASK

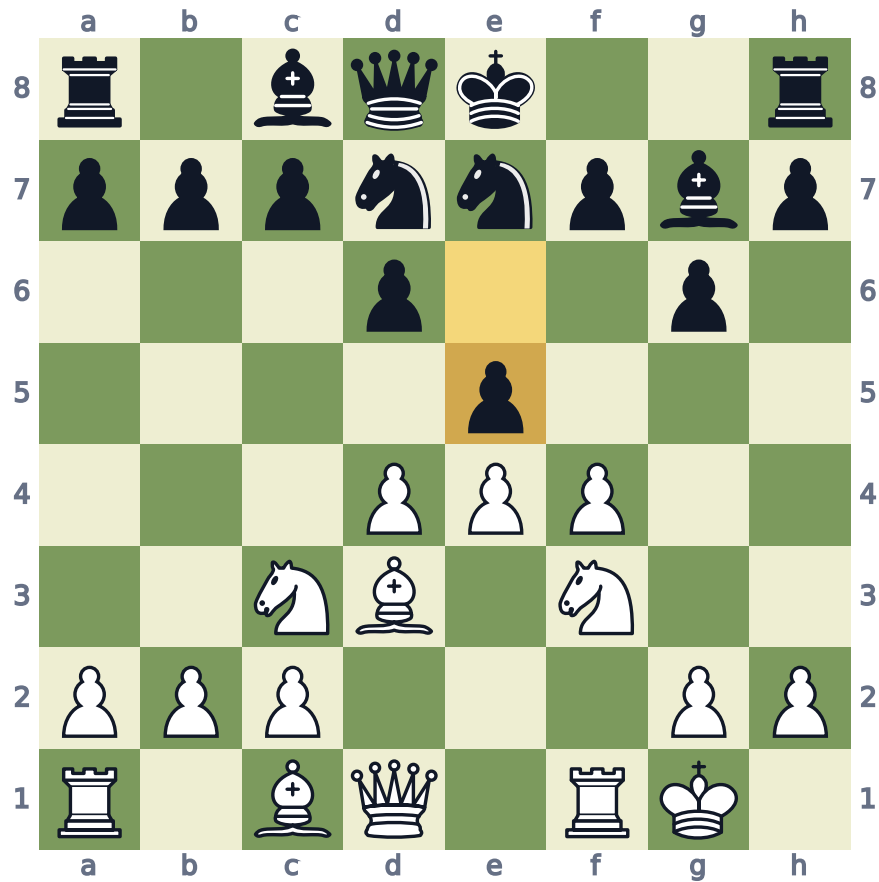
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

e5 against the Austrian center



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 Nd7 7. O-O e5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Hit d4 before White advances e5 and f5.

MAIN DANGER

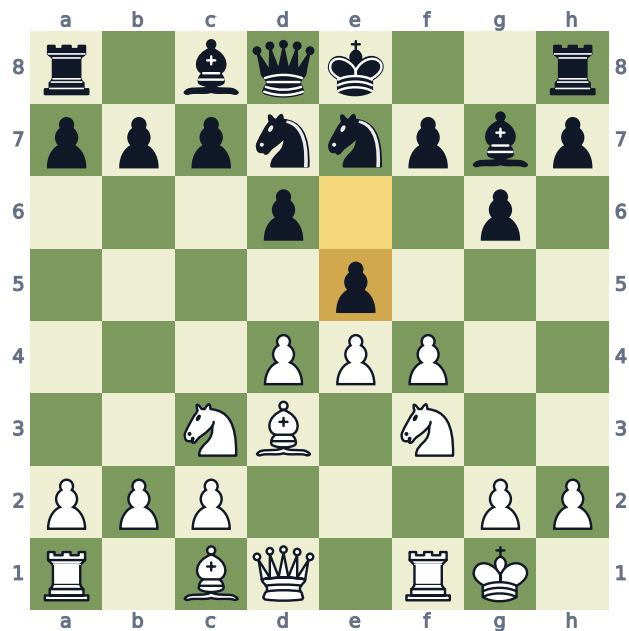
fxe5 can open the f-file and leave e6 sensitive.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against f4, e5 is a race against White's own e5 push.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

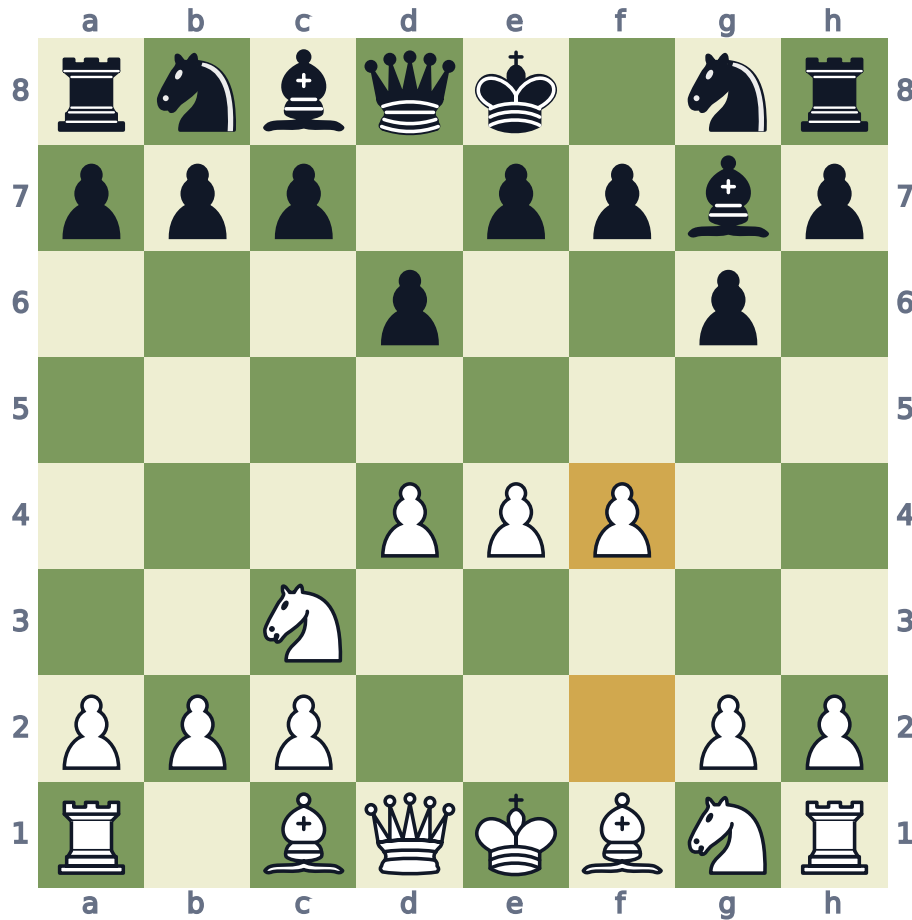
Position estimate: +2.52 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. fxe5 O-O 2. exd6 cxd6 3. a4 Nf6 4. Qe1 h6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

e5 against the Austrian center



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

e5 with White's c-pawn committed



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. f4 Ne7 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be2 e5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Fix or exchange the center, then use the c-pawn's commitment to choose queenside play.

MAIN DANGER

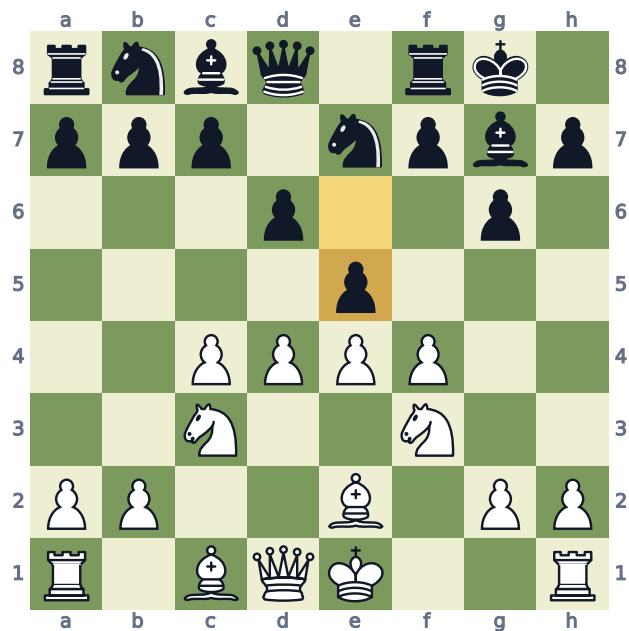
d5 may create a space clamp and a protected e4 pawn.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The broad center gives targets, but only if contact happens before it advances.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.45 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. fxe5 dxe5 2. d5 Nd7 3. O-O a5 4. Be3 b6 5. d6 cxd6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

e5 with White's c-pawn committed



YOUR TASK

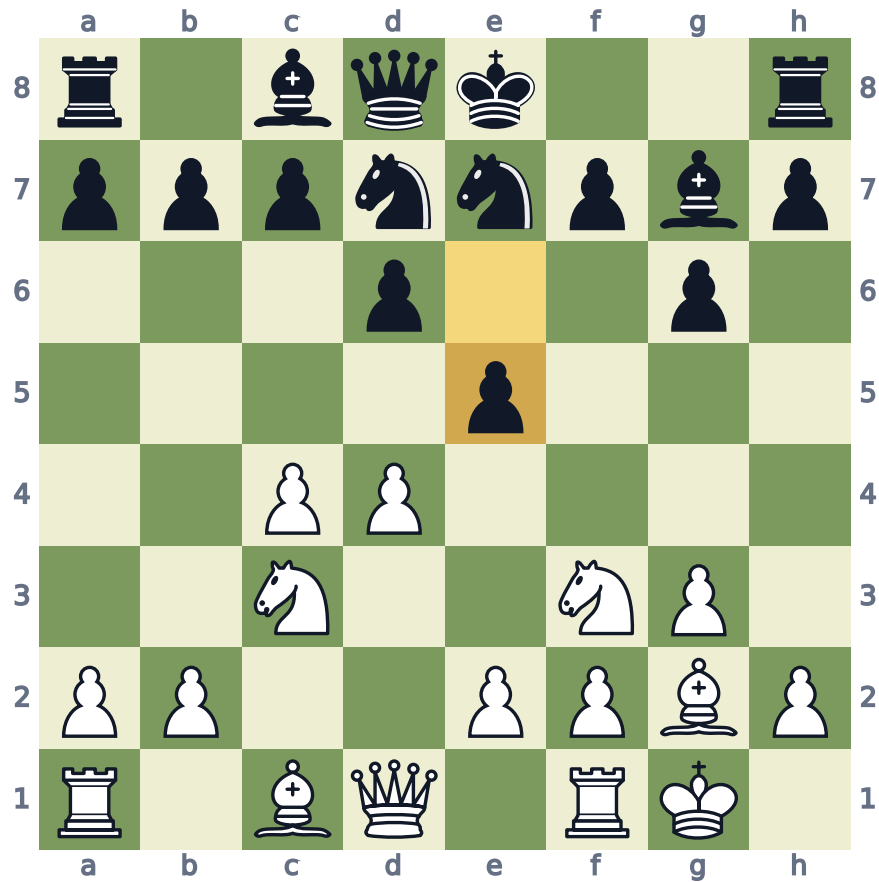
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

e5 in a fianchetto center

**COURSE LINE**

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. O-O Ne7 6. c4 Nd7 7. Nc3 e5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

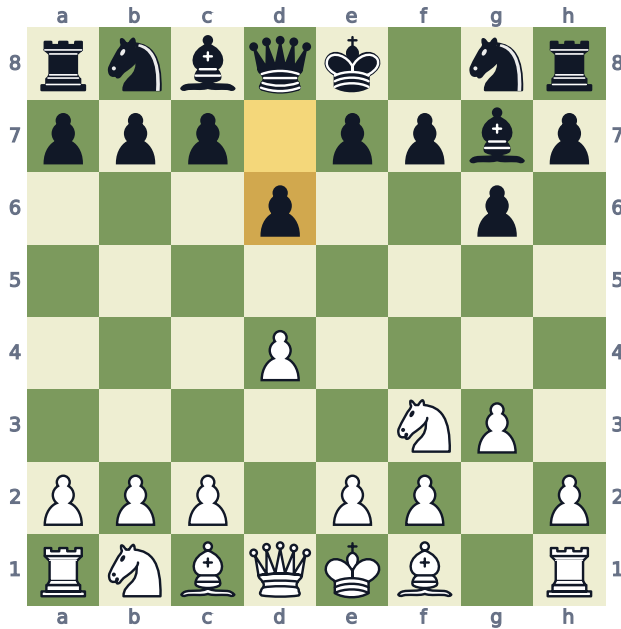
Challenge d4 while the g2 bishop and c-pawn define White's pressure.

MAIN DANGER

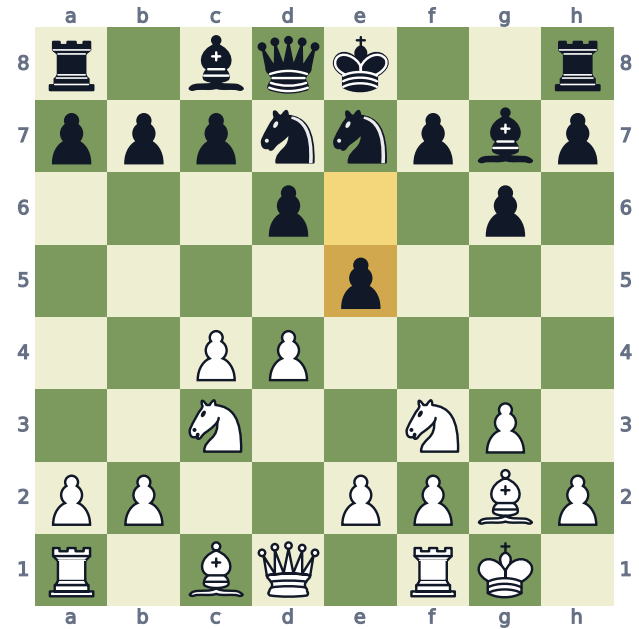
d5 can close Bg7 and give White queenside space.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

After e5-d5, plan the second break before accepting the closed center.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

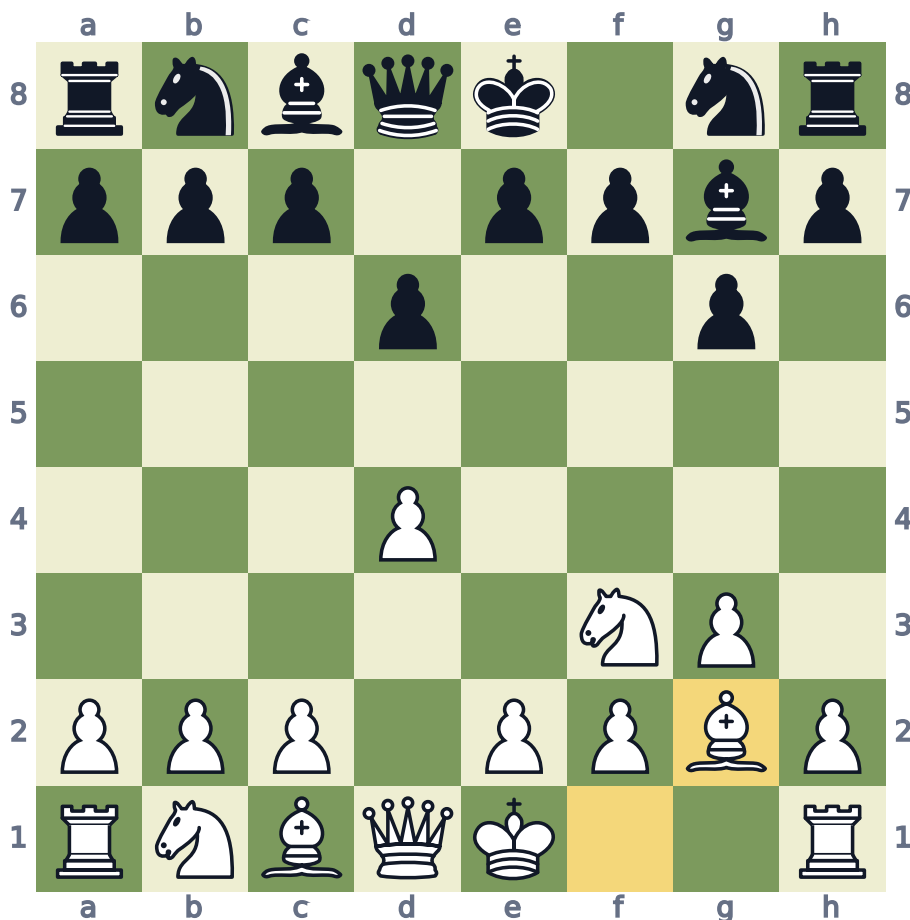
Position estimate: +1.20 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. dxe5 dxe5 2. b3 O-O 3. Qc2 Nf5 4. Rd1 Nd4 5. Nxd4 exd4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

e5 in a fianchetto center



YOUR TASK

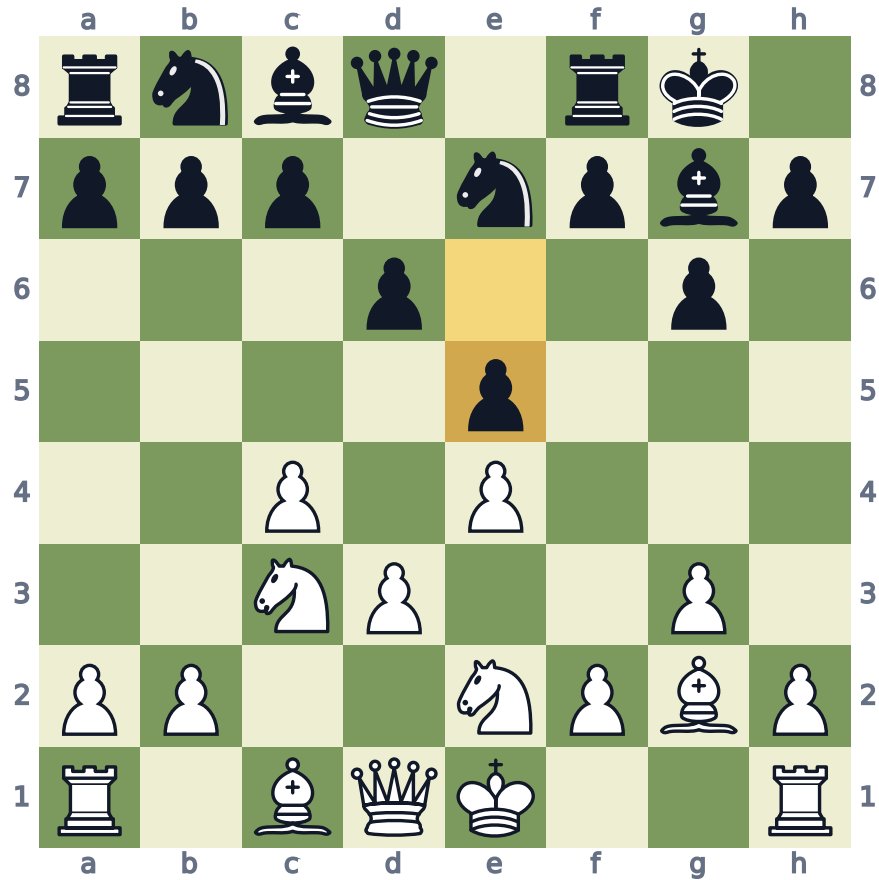
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

e5 against the Botvinnik English



COURSE LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. e4 O-O 7. Nge2 e5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Fix d4, restrain White's center, and prepare f5.

MAIN DANGER

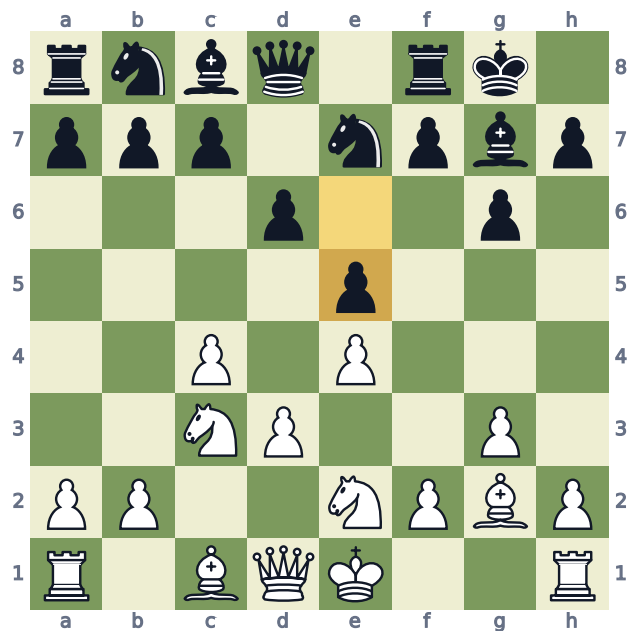
f4-f5 can attack before Black reorganizes.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

When White cannot play d4 easily, e5 can create a useful closed chain.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

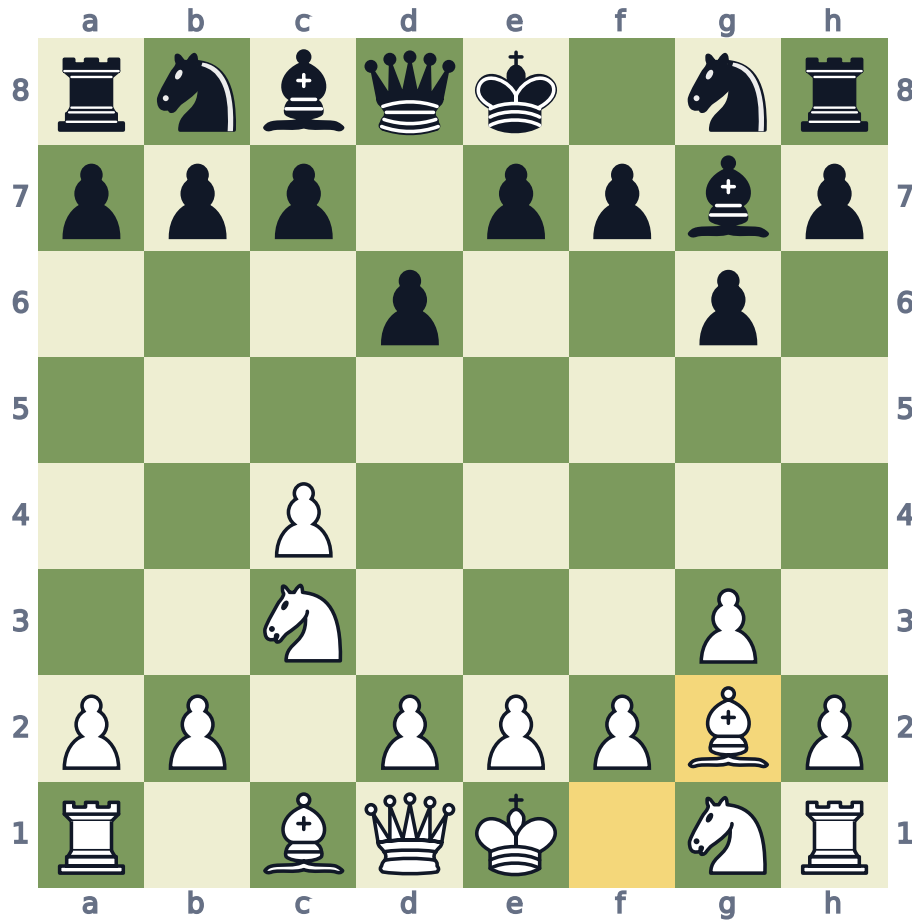
Position estimate: +0.56 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. b4 Bg4 2. Rb1 Qd7 3. h3 Be6 4. a4 Nbc6 5. b5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

e5 against the Botvinnik English



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

White closes before Black breaks



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. d5 e6 5. f4 exd5 6. Nxd5 Ne7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Exchange one central pawn and attack the advanced knight and remaining center.

MAIN DANGER

White may use c3 and f5 to support a lasting space edge.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A closed chain is not sacred; remove its base when the exchange improves development.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: -0.42 for White (Black is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Ne3 Nd7 2. Nf3 Nc5 3. Bd3 Bd7 4. O-O Bc6 5. f5 Nxex4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

White closes before Black breaks



YOUR TASK

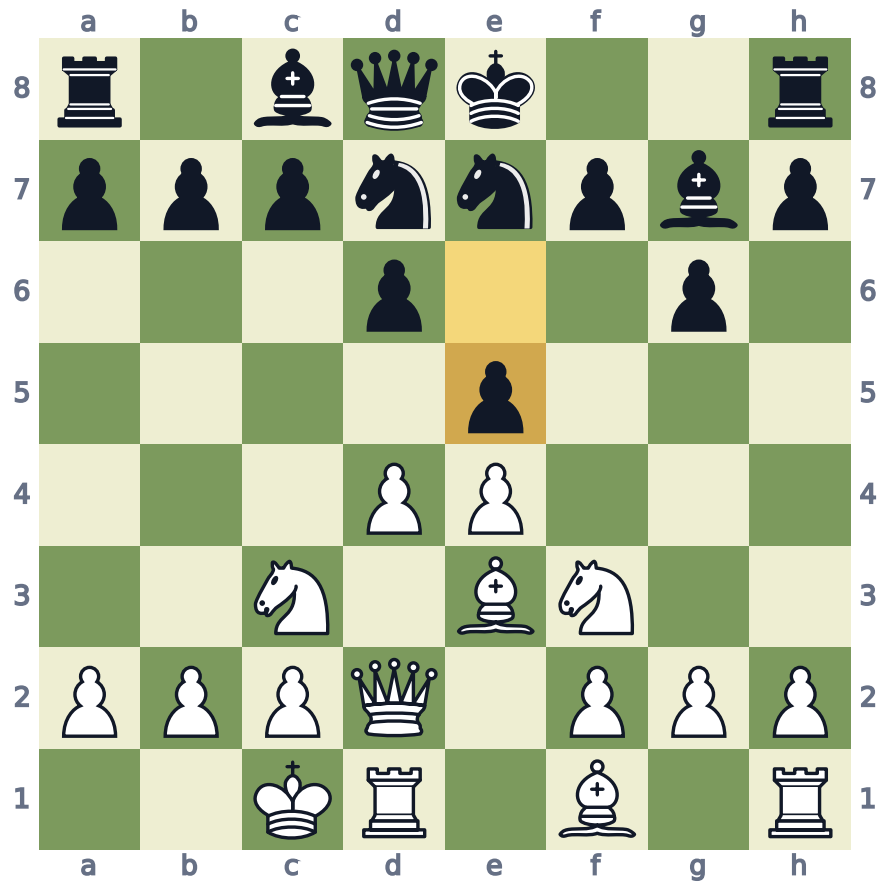
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

e5 against long castling



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e5 5. Be3 Ne7 6. Qd2 Nd7 7. O-O-O e5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Open central lines before White's kingside pawn storm becomes fast.

MAIN DANGER

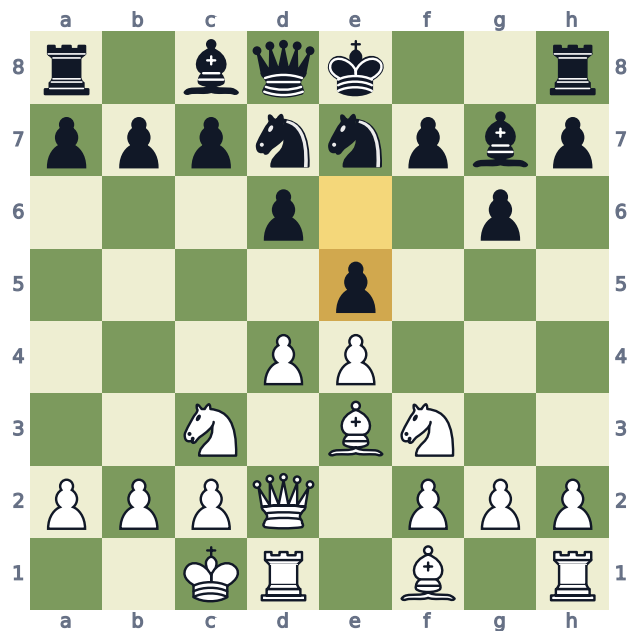
d5 can close the center and free White to attack the king.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against long castling, central contact and queenside files must be coordinated.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.98 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. dxe5 Nxe5 2. Nxe5 Bxe5 3. Bg5 h6 4. Bxh6 Bxc3 5. bxc3 Nc6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

e5 against long castling



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. E5 AGAINST THE CLASSICAL D4 CENTER

Course move: e6. Purpose: Attack d4, free the queen and knights, and force White to define the center. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. e5 d5 4. Na6 Qd2 5. Ng4 Bxg4 (+0.56 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 gains space and can leave Black's pieces short of squares.

02. E5 AGAINST A ROOK ON E1

Course move: e6. Purpose: Challenge d4 while using piece support to survive e-file tactics. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be3 2. O-O Qd2 3. Ng4 Bf4 4. c5 dxc5 5. dxc5 h3 (+0.64 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: dxe5 can expose the rook against the e-pawn or queen.

03. E5 AGAINST THE AUSTRIAN CENTER

Course move: e6. Purpose: Hit d4 before White advances e5 and f5. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Nf3 2. O-O Bd3 3. c5 dxc5 4. dxc5 h3 (+0.69 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: fxe5 can open the f-file and leave e6 sensitive.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. E5 WITH WHITE'S C-PAWN COMMITTED

Course move: e6. Purpose: Fix or exchange the center, then use the c-pawn's commitment to choose queenside play. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. e5 d5 4. Na6 Qd2 5. Ng4 Bxg4 (+0.56 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 may create a space clamp and a protected e4 pawn.

05. E5 IN A FIANCHETTO CENTER

Course move: e6. Purpose: Challenge d4 while the g2 bishop and c-pawn define White's pressure. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 c4 2. Nbd7 Nc3 3. O-O O-O 4. e5 Qc2 5. Re8 Be3 (+0.50 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 can close Bg7 and give White queenside space.

06. E5 AGAINST THE BOTVINNIK ENGLISH

Course move: e6. Purpose: Fix d4, restrain White's center, and prepare f5. Engine comparison: 1. Nc6 Rb1 2. a5 d3 3. Nf6 h3 4. O-O a3 5. e6 (+0.34 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: f4-f5 can attack before Black reorganizes.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. WHITE CLOSES BEFORE BLACK BREAKS

Course move: d6. Purpose: Exchange one central pawn and attack the advanced knight and remaining center. Engine comparison: 1. c6 Nf3 2. d5 e5 3. Bg4 h3 (+0.68 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: White may use c3 and f5 to support a lasting space edge.

08. E5 AGAINST LONG CASTLING

Course move: e6. Purpose: Open central lines before White's kingside pawn storm becomes fast. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be3 2. O-O Qd2 3. Ng4 Bf4 4. c5 dxc5 5. dxc5 h3 (+0.64 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 can close the center and free White to attack the king.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.